

Lecture 3

Writing Proposals

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A proposal is an offer from a ***seller*** to a ***prospective sponsor***

- The seller (that's you) wants to do something
- The prospective sponsor is the person who has to approve the course of action (usually because they are paying for it)

Types of Proposals

- Solicited
 - Your boss asks you for a solution to a problem
 - A company issues a Request for Proposals (RFP)
- Informally Solicited
 - A company with which you have a relationship asks for a new product or feature
- Unsolicited
 - You see an opportunity or problem and propose as solution
 - A salesperson proposes a new initiative with a customer

Proposals – The Rhetorical Situation

Consider an RFP for a machine learning solution that can predict machine failures in a manufacturing environment. What do we know about the rhetorical situation for our response?

As a reminder, we are looking for exigence, audience, purpose, constraints, and context

Proposals – The Rhetorical Situation

Exigence	
Audience	
Purpose	
Constraints	
Context	

Components of a Proposal

- Introduction
 - Similar to an executive summary
 - Defines the problem, stresses the importance, and describes the solution
- Background Information
 - Provides necessary information to understand the problem and the solution
 - Answers questions like: what is the problem? What causes the problem? What effects would solving the problem have?
- Plan
 - What will you do? What steps will you take? How long will it take?
- Assumptions and Risks
 - What is needed in order for this project to be doable (*e.g.* data must exist and be accessible)
 - What could happen that keeps you from executing the plan? What impact will that have?
- Conclusion
 - Reiterates key information from the proposal
 - Stresses the importance of taking action

Getting Started – Questions to Ask Yourself

When starting a proposal document or responding to an RFP, you need to make sure that you understand:

Problem and Audience

- The problem: what caused it and what are the effects?
- What does the audience know about the problem? What do they need to know?
- Why the audience should care about the problem: how does this problem affect business operations and objectives?
- How does the audience make decisions?
- What might (positively or negatively) influence the audience's decision?

Getting Started – Questions to Ask Yourself

The Proposed Solution

- What does your solution look like?
- What questions do you need to answer before you can complete the solution?
- How much will this cost?
- What tasks do you need to accomplish in order to complete the solution?
- What questions will the audience have about the proposed solution and your ability to complete it?
- Why is this solution better than others?

Project Planning

- There could be a whole course on project planning, but for this course I will keep it simple.
- Any project plan should have
 - Deliverables – Items and artifacts that you will complete during the project (such as progress reports or training scripts)
 - Deadlines – Target dates for when the deliverables will be done
 - Work items – A plan for what you will do to meet those deadlines

Deliverables

Market Appraisal Agent Prototype: A functional prototype of a single agentic AI agent focused on [REDACTED] to demonstrate stand-alone value:

- *Agent Functionality:* A coded agent capable of leveraging third-party data sources to perform [REDACTED] reducing risks related to data quality and access.
- *Proof-of-Concept Demonstration:* A working demo showcasing the agent's ability to [REDACTED], integrate with [REDACTED] tech stack, and deliver measurable value (e.g., faster analysis, improved accuracy).
- *User Feedback Plan:* A framework for collecting [REDACTED] feedback on the prototype to inform iterative refinements in subsequent phases.

4. Deliverables

- **Software-Oriented Deliverables:**
 - Pilot AI Solution in the Contractor's environment in accordance with [REDACTED] as per Section-2.
 - Configure [REDACTED] Azure environment to support operating the pilot per Section-2.
 - Pilot AI Solution operating in [REDACTED] environment in accordance with Section-2.
 - Interfaces: Establish connectivity from Pilot AI Solution to [REDACTED]'s OneDrive, SharePoint, and FileNet solutions in accordance with Section-2, and scope of the pilot.
 - Extended Pilot AI solution – enhance the Pilot AI solution to ingest selected data from [REDACTED] OneDrive, SharePoint, and FileNet solutions (referred to as the “as-built solution” from hereon), in accordance with Section-2.
 - Test environment in [REDACTED] Azure Environment.
- **Non-Software-Oriented Deliverables:**
 - Solution Design Document (describing the as-built solution) adhering to [REDACTED] template

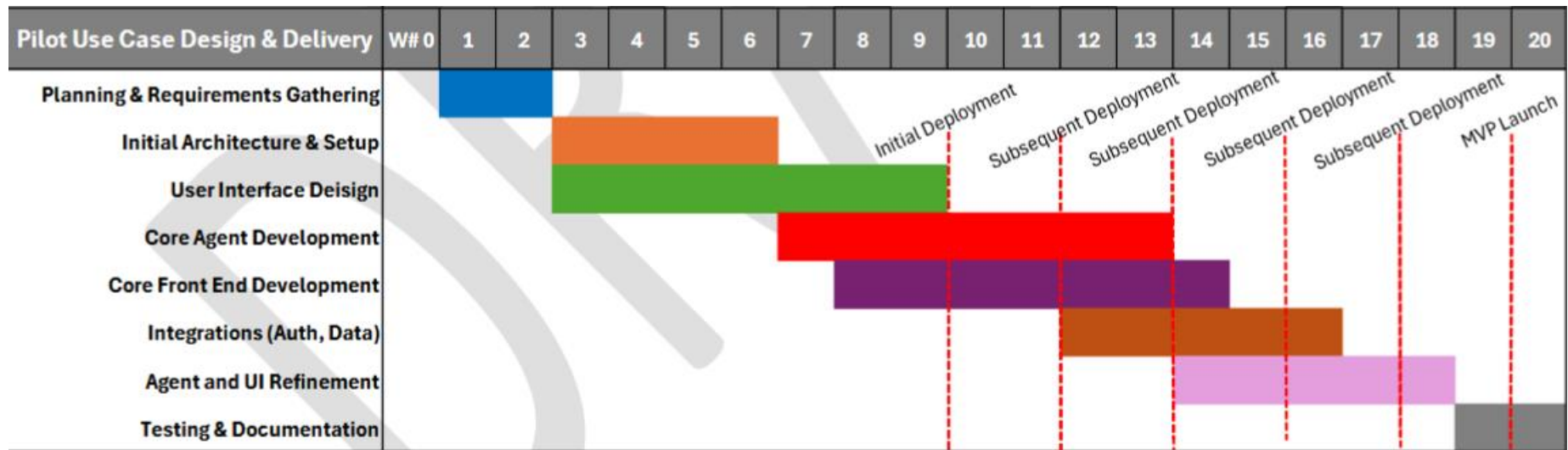
Deadlines

3.4 Key Dates

The following are the anticipated start and end dates for this project order. In the event that services are required beyond the end date, a Project Change Request will be submitted.

PO Start	September 09, 2024
PO End	February 27, 2025

Work Items



Assumptions and Risks

- **Assumptions** are items that you, the proposer, assume are true but you have not yet confirmed
 - “Access to data will be provided for the duration of the project”
 - “Sponsor will be available for regular progress updates”
- **Risks** are things that could go wrong during the project that would cause a delay
 - “Delays with getting access to required data, systems / applications, and stakeholders”
 - “Poor data quality and availability”
- A risk should have an estimated impact and mitigation plan

The Assignment

- You will write an ***informally solicited*** proposal to someone based on your analysis project
- Your goal is to convince them that this project is worth undertaking
- There is no fixed format or length, but you should include all the components we discussed earlier

Pre-Assignment Quiz

- Available on Canvas until Friday night
- For your project, provide the following (point/short form is okay)
 - The persona your team will be following (i.e. what organization are you making this analysis for, such as a car company, a sport team, and insurer, etc.)
 - The key decision your team's analysis will support
 - The data you will use in your analysis
 - The machine learning techniques you will use (very broadly, e.g. "We will predict the class of X based on factors A, B, C")